

There is a debate raging about Anthropogenic Global Warming (AGW), or Human-Induced Climate Change (HICC), or whatever acronym you choose to use to describe the effect billions of humans have had on the ecology of our planet.

Sadly, this debate has lost all sense of right and wrong, which is the norm for everything that's debated by those on the opposite sides of the political spectrum, or opposite sides of just about anything!

Discussions about anything serious, whether online or offline, have become a minefield that inevitably ends up blowing you up. Especially online, where you don't have to look someone in the eye, the tendency to just abuse, mock or personally attack anyone with an opinion that's different from yours is incredibly mind-numbing. What's worse, you might not even realise that this is also how you're treating people on the other side of the argument as yourself.

The facts about AGW are that we don't know for certain how bad the effects will be, or how fast we will arrive at the point of no return. That recent warming of the planet has been exacerbated or even been caused by humans is settled science. It's on par with the theory of evolution or the theory of gravity. Sure, in the future we might find that evolution occurred in several different ways we didn't know of before, or that Einstein's General Theory of Relativity needs to be replaced with something else... but we're not going to suddenly realise that gravity is actually a repulsive force, or that genetic changes were all done by alien microbiologists, and not by gradual changes in later generations... Add enough CO₂ or other greenhouse gases to a planet's atmosphere, the planet gets hotter.

So why is there a debate? We aren't sitting about fighting on social media about gravity, why do we fight about evolution, and why do we fight so much more about climate change?

Gravity is simple. Any fool can see a ball fall down when it's thrown up. The fact that said ball falls to the ground does not challenge any of our beliefs or biases. If falling balls went against our religion, or worse, against our wallets, you can bet we would have gravity deniers fighting tooth and nail, and calling Newton and Einstein shills for our political enemies...

So what is the truth? It doesn't matter. Trying to nail down the specifics about AGW is an exercise in pointlessness. It's best left to the scientists anyway, because if you were to actually read a climate scientist's paper, most of us wouldn't understand any of the jargon anyway!

This cover story is an attempt to try and do something different. Let's look at this in a different way. If you were given two buttons to choose from, and told that you had to press one, no matter what, the first question you would ask is what do the buttons do. So here are the two options:

- Button A might cost you some extra money by making you do things that are completely pointless.
- Button B might kill off a few thousand species of animals, and might harm some humans as well.

Is this really a choice worth fighting about? Instead of wasting pages in this magazine about avoiding Button A, we're going with how you can minimise your carbon footprint, just so that you can sleep better at night, without having the suffering of future generations on your mind.

We're also going to be looking at some impressive actions that Indians and Indian startups have taken in order to help us reduce the impact we have on the earth's ecology. We're also going to look at some interesting new technologies that promise to reverse the effects we've had. After all, it was our technological growth that caused all those gases to be spewed into our atmosphere, so why can't we use the same technology to fix what we did? There's more about how you can recycle hardware, and of course what technologies have become available to meet our rather hungry power needs.

This is just the tip of the iceberg though, because there are no doubt many, many more ways in which you can reduce your impact on the planet. Using solar power as much as you can, reducing travel, walking or cycling more... Using your gadgets for longer before you upgrade, buying more future-proof devices... there are so many little things that all add up over time. Remember to write in to editor@digit.in and tell us what you do to reduce your footprint on the planet, and whether this cover story has inspired you to change. 